

FROM 1 OCTOBER 2026

WhatsApp just put a price on your empty replies.

Every reply a business sends on the WhatsApp Business Platform is now billed. Here is why that is good news, if you read it right.

WHAT CHANGES

Free replies end on 1 October.

1

Every service reply is charged

Replies sent inside the 24-hour window, by a person or a bot. Free since November 2024.

2

Roughly 12 cents a message

Billed in US dollars, so the rand cost moves. Local providers estimate 10 to 15 cents.

3

Platform only, not the app

Hits chatbots, CRMs and API providers. The free WhatsApp Business app is not affected.

COUNT YOUR OWN FLOW

Hi, how much for a two-day conference package for 40 people?

Hi there! 🖐️

BILLED

Welcome to our business

BILLED

Please choose an option below

BILLED

Reply 1, 2 or 3

BILLED

Thanks! Your request is noted

BILLED

Someone will be in touch

BILLED

6 messages. 0 answers.

THE MATHS, AT 2,000 INQUIRIES A MONTH

The fee is cheap. The flow is not.

PADDED FLOW

12,000

billed replies a month
(6 per inquiry)

≈ R1,440

A menu and a wait

TIGHT FLOW

4,000

billed replies a month
(2 per inquiry)

≈ R480

An answer and a next step

Illustrative example at about 12 cents a reply. The real cost is the buyers who quit on the menu: 81% of SA consumers had a bad service experience in 2026, and only 24% said so publicly (2026 SA Customer Experience Report).

THE FIX, THIS WEEK

One message that **does three jobs.**

1

Answer what they asked

Not a confirmation that they asked.

2

Ask one question

Something that qualifies, answerable in a sentence.

3

Offer a next step with a time

"10:00 or 14:00 tomorrow?" beats "someone will be in touch."

Full breakdown: novapex.agency/blog